

Angel investors for GuardSpine's AI governance infrastructure round

Twenty specific individuals with verified investment activity offer strong fit for a \$500K–\$1M angel check in GuardSpine's work provenance infrastructure. These candidates span three archetypes — Compliance-Scarred Operators who lived the audit pain, DevTools Founders who built and exited analogous companies, and Regulatory-Thesis Investors who explicitly back governance infrastructure. The strongest signal across all five research vectors: the compliance-security-AI governance investing ecosystem is tightly interconnected, with many of these individuals already co-investing in adjacent companies like Drata, Socket.dev, Secureframe, and Credo AI. GuardSpine's open-core model, Rust/crypto engineering stack, and EU AI Act timing align precisely with what these investors have publicly said they want to fund.

Compliance-Scarred Operators who write personal checks

These individuals have spent careers navigating enterprise compliance at scale and now invest in tools that solve the pain they experienced firsthand.

1. Phil Venables

- **Current role:** VP/CISO, Google Cloud
- **Background:** Former CISO of Goldman Sachs. One of the most respected CISOs globally. Invested personally in **Socket.dev** (Series B, confirmed in Socket's blog and Globe Newswire announcement).
[GlobeNewswire](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Has governed security compliance at the world's most regulated institutions. Deeply understands the audit evidence problem. His Google Cloud role gives visibility into how enterprises will need AI governance infrastructure.
- **Profile match:** Compliance-Scarred Operator
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/philvenables](https://www.linkedin.com/in/philvenables)

2. David B. Cross

- **Current role:** CISO, Atlassian; Venture Partner at Rain Capital ([RocketReach](#)) (cybersecurity fund)
- **Background:** 30+ years in cybersecurity. ([Equilar](#)) Former CISO of Oracle SaaS Cloud, ([OX Security](#)) 17 years at Microsoft (Windows/Azure security), US Navy veteran ([Equilar](#)) (electronic warfare, encryption). **30+ patents in security IP.** ([Equilar](#)) Angel invested in StepSecurity (\$3M seed), ([Stepsecurity](#)) Twistlock ([ContactOut](#)) (acquired by Palo Alto Networks), Toucan, ([RocketReach](#)) POSaBIT. ([ContactOut](#))
- **Check size:** \$100K–\$5M range per NFX Signal, **\$1.5M sweet spot** ([Signal](#)) — perfectly aligned with target range.

- **Why GuardSpine:** Lives the CISO compliance pain daily at Atlassian. Spoke on "CISOs under indictment" panel at RSA (Substack) — understands personal liability driving governance tool adoption. Rain Capital affiliation extends his network into cybersecurity VC ecosystem.
- **Profile match:** Compliance-Scarred Operator
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/david-b-cross-b856657

3. Caleb Sima

- **Current role:** Founding General Partner, WhiteRabbit (cybersecurity venture studio); Chair, CSA AI Security Initiative (partnered with Amazon, Anthropic, Google, Microsoft, OpenAI)
- **Background:** Founded SPI Dynamics (acquired by HP) and BlueBox Security (acquired by Lookout). Former CSO at Robinhood, Security CTO at Databricks, Managing VP Cyber Security at Capital One. (Black Hat) 35+ angel investments including Drata, Endor Labs, Orca, JupiterOne, Island, Tines, Veza, Bridgecrew, Fossa. SVCI member. 20+ patents.
- **Why GuardSpine:** Chairs the CSA AI Safety Initiative — sits at the exact intersection of AI governance and security investing. Created Black Hat's Entrepreneur Summit. His portfolio is the most compliance/security-dense angel portfolio found in this research.
- **Profile match:** Compliance-Scarred Operator / DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/calebsima

4. Niloofar Razi Howe

- **Current role:** President, The Stratham Group; Operating Partner, Capitol Meridian Partners (government-tech investing); Distinguished Visiting Professor, Vanderbilt National Security Institute
- **Background:** Former CSO at RSA Security and Endgame (acquired by Elastic). Harvard Law JD. 12 years in PE/VC (Zone Ventures, Paladin Capital). Judge at RSA Innovation Sandbox Competition. Board member at Tenable (NASDAQ: TENB), Morgan Stanley Banks. CISA Advisory Council member. Advisor to Hidden Layer, Blackbird.ai, Altana.ai, Dragos. (Vanderbilt University Owen Gr...)
- **Explicitly described as angel investor** investing mainly in seed and early-stage rounds (Ask For Funding) per AskForFunding.com.
- **Why GuardSpine:** Evaluates security startups as RSA Innovation Sandbox judge. Government advisory roles (CISA, DHS, NSA, DoD) give her unmatched insight into regulatory direction. Capitol Meridian's government-tech thesis directly maps to AI governance infrastructure.
- **Profile match:** Regulatory-Thesis Investor / Compliance-Scarred Operator
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/niloofarhowe

5. Richard Seiersen

- **Current role:** Chief Risk Technology Officer, Qualys
 - **Background:** Co-founded Soluble (cloud security, sold to Lacework 2021). 3x Fortune 100 CISO (GE Healthcare, Twilio, LendingClub). Author of *How To Measure Anything In Cybersecurity Risk* and *The Metrics Manifesto* — the definitive books on quantifying security compliance. Board member of FAIR Institute. IANS Research CISO Faculty consulting 250+ Fortune-level organizations.
 - **Why GuardSpine:** Literally wrote the books on creating evidence-based compliance measurement. His entire career thesis is that governance requires cryptographically rigorous, quantifiable evidence — exactly what GuardSpine builds. A Richard Seiersen endorsement would be a signal flare to every CISO buyer.
 - **Profile match:** Compliance-Scarred Operator
 - **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/richardseiersen](https://www.linkedin.com/in/richardseiersen)
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DevTools founders who exited and now deploy capital

These founders built developer infrastructure companies, navigated acquisition or IPO exits, and now angel invest in the next generation. They understand the open-core playbook GuardSpine is running.

6. Guy Podjarny

- **Current role:** Founder & CEO, Tessl AI; [Google Cloud](#) Advisor, Boldstart Ventures [PitchBook](#)
- **Background:** Founded **Snyk** (developer security, scaled to **\$8.5B valuation**). [Tracxn](#) Previously founded Blaze.io (acquired by Akamai). [Fastgrowthicons](#) Former CTO at Akamai. [Fastgrowthicons](#) **100+ angel investments** per Google Cloud bio. [Google Cloud](#) [PitchBook](#) 15+ patents in security. [PitchBook](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Built the category-defining developer-first security company using the exact open-core, developer-adoption-first playbook GuardSpine is running. His Boldstart advisory role connects into the enterprise seed ecosystem. Writes checks frequently at angel scale.
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/guypod](https://www.linkedin.com/in/guypod)

7. Jon Oberheide

- **Current role:** Board member & angel investor (formerly Co-founder & CTO, Duo Security)
- **Background:** Co-founded Duo Security, acquired by **Cisco for \$2.35 billion** in 2018. PhD in Computer Science (Michigan). Angel invested in **Secureframe** (Series B), [Secureframe](#) plus DNSFilter, runZero, Push Security, Dropzone AI, Sublime Security, Corridor Security (~9+ investments). [Tracxn](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Duo's zero-trust platform is foundational to enterprise compliance. Post-acquisition, Jon invests off his own balance sheet in cybersecurity and enterprise SaaS. [Prog.AI](#) His \$2.35B exit gives

significant personal capital for angel checks.

- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/jonoberheide

8. Dug Song

- **Current role:** Managing Director, Cisco Investments; Co-founder, Duo Security
- **Background:** Co-founded Duo Security (\$2.35B acquisition by Cisco). (Tracxn) PhD in Computer Science. Created foundational security tools (dsniff, fragroute). **Founder Advisor at Decibel Partners.** Confirmed angel investor (participated alongside Unusual Ventures in Vizcom's seed round, among others).
- **Why GuardSpine:** Duo pioneered making security accessible and user-friendly for enterprises — the same ethos GuardSpine applies to AI governance. His Decibel advisory role and Cisco Investments position provide dual pathways (personal angel + strategic).
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder / Compliance-Scarred Operator
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/dugsong

9. Solomon Hykes

- **Current role:** Co-Founder & CEO, Dagger (CI/CD pipeline tools) (Arete-Index)
- **Background:** Co-founded **Docker** (containerization platform). **24–29 angel investments** including (Ask For Funding) Supabase, Algolia, GitGuardian, PostHog, Recall.ai. (Tracxn) YC alum (dotCloud). (Arete-Index)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Docker pioneered the open-source-to-commercial infrastructure model. His investment in **GitGuardian** (developer security/secrets detection) shows direct thesis alignment with developer-first security tooling. Understands container-level provenance and supply chain trust.
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/solomonhykes

10. Jesse Robbins

- **Current role:** General Partner, Heavybit (Crunchbase) (developer tools fund)
- **Background:** Co-founded **Chef Software** (infrastructure automation, acquired by **Progress for \$240M**). Amazon's original "Master of Disaster" (Wikipedia) (site reliability). Founded O'Reilly Velocity Conference (launched the DevOps movement). Angel portfolio includes early positions in **Fastly (NYSE: FSLY)**, **PagerDuty (NYSE: PD)**, **CircleCI**, **Instacart**. Named to "Seed 100: Best Early-Stage Investors of 2021." (Wikipedia)

- **Why GuardSpine:** Chef's infrastructure-as-code model maps directly to governance-as-code patterns. His Heavybit role means he actively evaluates developer tools at seed stage. The Chef → Progress exit is the exact "developer adoption → enterprise sales → acquisition" playbook.
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/jesserobbins](https://www.linkedin.com/in/jesserobbins)

11. Luke Kanies

- **Current role:** Angel investor (formerly Founder & Executive Chairman, Puppet)
- **Background:** Founded **Puppet** (infrastructure automation, [Puppet](#)) acquired by **Perforce** for ~\$530M in 2022). Angel investments include fastCode, Vorstellia, GitLab, Wallaroo Labs, Fleetsmith. [AngelList](#) Self-describes as angel investor "mostly in areas of expertise (infrastructure and dev tools)." [Hachyderm](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Puppet pioneered infrastructure-as-code with an open-source model that went enterprise — the exact same motion GuardSpine is executing. The \$530M Perforce exit sits squarely in the target acquisition range. Publicly states he is "default-accept on first conversations." [Hachyderm](#)
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** [linkedin.com/in/lukekanies](https://www.linkedin.com/in/lukekanies)

12. Moritz Plassnig

- **Current role:** Chief Product Officer, Immuta (data security/governance) [Qwoted](#)
- **Background:** Co-founded **Codship** (CI/CD, acquired by CloudBees [Entrepreneur](#) 2018). Board member of CloudSkiff (acquired by Snyk). [Moritzplassnig](#) **6+ angel investments** at \$5–25K in data, dev tool, and security startups. Investments include Stellate, DX, Liveblocks, Acquire.com. [PitchBook](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Currently CPO at a **data governance company** (Immuta) — lives the compliance infrastructure problem daily. His Codship acquisition experience plus Snyk orbit (via CloudSkiff board) means he deeply understands the developer security market dynamics. Explicitly states he invests in "data, dev, and security companies." [GitHub](#) [Moritzplassnig](#)
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** Search "Moritz Plassnig Immuta"; website: moritzplassnig.com/angel-investments

13. Adam Wiggins

- **Current role:** Co-founder & Partner, Muse; Co-founder, Ink & Switch (research lab); Advisor, Heavybit [Crunchbase](#)
- **Background:** Co-founder and former CTO of **Heroku** [Medium](#) (pioneering PaaS, acquired by **Salesforce** for ~\$212M). Created the Twelve-Factor App methodology. **23+ tracked angel investments** [PitchBook](#) including Netlify (unicorn), [Tracxn](#) PartyKit, Anytype, tldraw, ElectricSQL, CrabNebula.

- **Why GuardSpine:** Heroku defined the platform experience for developers. His Heavybit advisory role keeps him in the developer tools deal flow. Deep understanding of developer workflows where governance needs to be embedded invisibly.
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/adamwiggins (approximate)

14. Mark Curphey

- **Current role:** Co-Founder & CMO, Crash Override (security startup) (SC Media)
 - **Background: Founded OWASP** (the most influential open-source security project globally). (Wikipedia) (PRWeb) Founded SourceClear (software composition analysis, acquired by CA Technologies/Veracode). (Wikipedia +2) Co-founded Open Raven (data security, acquired by Formstack). (Tracxn) Three-time security company founder with advisory board that included George Kurtz (CrowdStrike CEO). (PRWeb)
 - **Why GuardSpine:** The OWASP founder understands developer-first security adoption better than almost anyone. SourceClear's open-source composition analysis is conceptually adjacent to GuardSpine's work provenance for AI-assisted code. (Wikipedia) Even as an advisor rather than check-writer, his endorsement carries enormous weight.
 - **Profile match:** DevTools Founder / Compliance-Scarred Operator
 - **LinkedIn:** Search "Mark Curphey Crash Override"
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Regulatory-Thesis Investors betting on governance as a category

These individuals have explicit, public investment theses around AI regulation creating investable markets. They view the EU AI Act and similar frameworks as market catalysts — exactly GuardSpine's thesis.

15. Mohamed Nanabhay

- **Current role:** Managing Partner, Mozilla Ventures (\$35M+ impact venture fund) (Global Venturing)
- **Background:** Former Deputy CEO, Media Development Investment Fund. Former Head of New Media, Al Jazeera. (OECD AI) OECD AI Expert. **Invested in essentially every major AI governance company:** Credo AI, Holistic AI, Fiddler AI, Themis AI, Trail (AI legal compliance), Armilla AI (AI insurance), Vera, TruePic. (Mozilla)
- **Check size:** \$100K–\$5M, **\$1.5M sweet spot** (EasyVC) — aligns perfectly with target range.
- **Why GuardSpine:** The single most active investor in the AI governance stack globally. Has publicly stated: "Organizations of all sizes want to embrace AI innovation while maintaining compliance in a fast-evolving regulatory landscape." (Business Wire) GuardSpine's cryptographic evidence bundles fill a specific infrastructure gap in his existing portfolio.

- **Profile match:** Regulatory-Thesis Investor
- **LinkedIn:** uk.linkedin.com/in/mohamedn

16. Ian Hogarth

- **Current role:** Chair, UK AI Safety Institute; Co-Founder & Partner, Plural Platform (VC)
- **Background:** Co-authored the influential annual *State of AI Report*. [Wikipedia](#) Wrote "AI Nationalism." YC alum (co-founded Songkick). [Wikipedia](#) **100+ startup investments, 50+ specifically in AI/ML**, including Anthropic, [Media Clicks](#) ComplyAdvantage (regtech), Faculty, Unitary (AI content moderation). [The Network](#) Appointed to lead the world's first state-backed AI safety organization (£100M government funding).
- **Check size:** Typically \$5K–\$50K (smaller angel checks, but massive signal value). [Media Clicks](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** His government role gives him unmatched insight into regulatory enforcement timelines — he literally shapes AI governance policy. An investment from Hogarth would be a credibility accelerant across the entire EU AI Act compliance market.
- **Profile match:** Regulatory-Thesis Investor
- **LinkedIn:** uk.linkedin.com/in/ianhogarth

17. Nathan Benaich

- **Current role:** Founder & General Partner, Air Street Capital
- **Background:** PhD in Biology (Cambridge). [Hidden Forces](#) Co-authors the *State of AI Report* [Zeta Alpha](#) with Hogarth. [Wikipedia](#) Publishes weekly essays on Air Street Press/Substack covering AI regulation and investment implications. His 2025 report noted: "Europe's AI Act is wobbling: only 3 states are compliant." [Substack](#)
- **Why GuardSpine:** Consistently frames regulation as both risk and opportunity. His platform (State of AI Report is the most widely-read independent AI analysis globally) could amplify GuardSpine's narrative. Pre-seed to seed focus aligns with stage.
- **Profile match:** Regulatory-Thesis Investor
- **Substack:** nathanbenaich.substack.com

18. Frederic Kerrest

- **Current role:** Co-Founder & Vice Chairman, Okta; Managing Partner, 515 Ventures
- **Background:** Co-founded Okta (NASDAQ: OKTA), the leading identity platform. [PitchBook](#) Author of *Zero to IPO*. **40+ angel investments** [Tracxn](#) including Socket.dev (Series A), Chainguard (Series C), SecurityPal, SECURITI.ai, System Two Security, Doppel.

- **Why GuardSpine:** Okta underpins enterprise identity compliance — Kerrest intimately understands how identity, access, and governance intersect. His portfolio shows a clear thesis around security/compliance infrastructure. Multiple investments in supply chain security (Socket.dev, Chainguard) signal interest in provenance and trust.
 - **Profile match:** DevTools Founder / Regulatory-Thesis Investor
 - **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/fkerrest
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Two high-value strategic names worth pursuing

19. Olivier Pomel

- **Current role:** Co-Founder & CEO, Datadog (NYSE: DDOG)
- **Background:** Built Datadog into a \$40B+ public company. **50+ angel investments** [Ask For Funding](#) including Drata (compliance automation), Miro, Replit, Dataiku, Bigeye, Moderne, Resolvd AI.
- **Why GuardSpine:** His Drata investment explicitly signals conviction that compliance automation is critical infrastructure for developers. Datadog's observability platform is conceptually adjacent — if observability became essential for ops, governance evidence becomes essential for AI work. CEO-level signal value is enormous.
- **Profile match:** DevTools Founder
- **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/olivierpomel

20. Sounil Yu

- **Current role:** Co-Founder & Chief AI Safety Officer, Knostic (AI access controls for generative AI)
 - **Background:** Created the **Cyber Defense Matrix** (the "periodic table for cybersecurity") and the DIE Triad. Former CISO at JupiterOne, Chief Security Scientist at Bank of America. SVCI member. 20+ patents. RSA Conference workshop presenter (multiple years). Security Magazine's Most Influential People (2020).
 - **Why GuardSpine:** His company Knostic builds AI access controls [ZoomInfo](#) — directly adjacent and potentially complementary to GuardSpine's evidence bundles. He would immediately grasp the cryptographic provenance concept. His frameworks are used by investors to evaluate security market gaps. Guest lecturer at Carnegie Mellon, Fellow at GMU Scalia Law School National Security Institute.
 - **Profile match:** DevTools Founder / Regulatory-Thesis Investor
 - **LinkedIn:** linkedin.com/in/sounil
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Priority outreach matrix

Priority	Name	Archetype	Check fit	Key signal
Tier 1	Mohamed Nanabhay	Regulatory- Thesis	\$1.5M sweet spot	Invested in 7+ AI governance companies
Tier 1	Caleb Sima	Compliance Operator	\$350K+ via SVCI	Chairs CSA AI Safety Initiative, 35+ security deals
Tier 1	Guy Podjarny	DevTools Founder	Active at angel scale	100+ investments, Google Cloud PitchBook built Snyk's open-core model
Tier 1	David B. Cross	Compliance Operator	\$1.5M sweet spot	Rain Capital VP, Signal CISO at Atlassian
Tier 1	Frederic Kerrest	Hybrid	Active angel	Okta co-founder, 40+ investments in security
Tier 2	Jon Oberheide	DevTools Founder	Post-\$2.35B exit	Duo CTO, invests in compliance tools
Tier 2	Niloofar Razi Howe	Regulatory- Thesis	Seed-stage angel	RSA judge, Capitol Meridian, CISA advisor
Tier 2	Jesse Robbins	DevTools Founder	Heavybit GP	Chef founder, Seed 100 list
Tier 2	Phil Venables	Compliance Operator	Strategic angel	Google Cloud CISO, ex-Goldman CISO
Tier 2	Solomon Hykes	DevTools Founder	Active angel	Docker founder, Ask For Funding invested in GitGuardian
Tier 2	Ian Hogarth	Regulatory- Thesis	\$25K typical	UK AI Safety Institute chair
Tier 3	Luke Kanies	DevTools Founder	Active angel	Puppet founder, Puppet \$530M exit
Tier 3	Olivier Pomel	DevTools Founder	Strategic angel	Datadog CEO, invested in Drata
Tier 3	Dug Song	DevTools Founder	Post-exit capital	Duo co-founder, Decibel advisor

Priority	Name	Archetype	Check fit	Key signal
Tier 3	Richard Seiersen	Compliance Operator	Founder/operator	Wrote the books on compliance measurement
Tier 3	Adam Wiggins	DevTools Founder	\$23+ investments	Heroku co-founder, Heavybit advisor
Tier 3	Nathan Benaich	Regulatory- Thesis	Fund-level seed	State of AI Report, Air Street Capital
Tier 3	Moritz Plassnig	DevTools Founder	\$5–25K checks (GitHub)	Codeship founder, now CPO at Immuta (governance) (Qwoted)
Tier 3	Sounil Yu	Hybrid	SVCI member	Knostic founder, Cyber Defense Matrix creator
Tier 3	Mark Curphey	DevTools Founder	Advisory value	OWASP founder, 3x security founder

Three network multipliers to unlock multiple names at once

Beyond individual outreach, three collective networks surfaced repeatedly and could unlock several investors through a single introduction.

SVCI (Silicon Valley CISO Investments) is a syndicate of **70+ practicing CISOs** who co-invest \$350K+ per deal. (SVCI+2) Members include Caleb Sima, Sounil Yu, David B. Cross, and CISOs from Coinbase, Adobe, ICE/NYSE, and DigiCert. (CB Insights) SVCI recently invested in Noma Security (enterprise AI security/governance). (CB Insights) A single SVCI presentation could reach dozens of qualified buyers-turned-investors simultaneously. (SVCI)

The Duo Security orbit — Jon Oberheide, Dug Song, and Ash Devata (Stepsecurity) all came from Cisco's \$2.35B Duo acquisition and now angel invest in security/compliance tools. Reaching one likely surfaces introductions to the others.

The Drata angel syndicate — Olivier Pomel, Caleb Sima, Jennifer Tejada (PagerDuty CEO), Frank Sloatman (Snowflake CEO), and Amit Agarwal (Datadog President) all personally invested in Drata's compliance automation platform. (Drata) This cohort has already validated the "compliance infrastructure" thesis with their own capital.

Positioning notes for outreach

GuardSpine should frame differently for each archetype. For **Compliance-Scarred Operators** (Venables, Cross, Sima, Seiersen), lead with the EU AI Act August 2026 enforcement date and the audit evidence gap — these people know the pain of producing compliance artifacts under time pressure. For **DevTools Founders** (Podjarny, Oberheide, Hykes, Robbins, Kanies), lead with the open-core model, Rust/crypto engineering stack, and the developer-adoption-first GTM — they'll pattern-match to Snyk, HashiCorp, and Docker. For **Regulatory-Thesis Investors** (Nanabhay, Hogarth, Benaich, Howe), lead with the market timing narrative: EU AI Act creates mandatory compliance demand on a fixed deadline, and GuardSpine's BYOK architecture means enterprises can adopt without data sovereignty concerns.

One important caveat: several Regulatory-Thesis investors (Nanabhay, Hogarth) have existing investments in Credo AI or adjacent AI governance companies. GuardSpine should position as **complementary infrastructure** (work provenance evidence layer) rather than competitive with existing portfolio companies. The cryptographic evidence bundle approach occupies a distinct technical layer beneath policy-level governance platforms.